Where You Are: Medicaid Readiness, Step Three of Nine, and What Comes After It

The nine steps of the Medicaid Planning Roadmap, with yours marked.

When Medicaid first comes up for a parent who is doing fine, it's hard to tell whether there is one thing to understand or a hundred. There's an order to it, and you're near the beginning.

This page shows the whole road, where you are on it, and what comes next.

Phase 1 · Assess

Understand where you are today.

1. **Understand** Care Needs → Levels of Care & Costs → Care Plan
   You finish with: Future Care Planning Assessment

2. **Organize** Income & Assets → Ownership & Expenses → Financial File
   You finish with: Family Financial Inventory

3. **Assess** Care & Nonfinancial Eligibility → Income & Assets → Barriers & Readiness
   You finish with: Medicaid Readiness Assessment

   You are here. This step is about understanding where Mom stands today. It moves from her care needs and the basic requirements, to her income and assets, to anything that could affect eligibility later. You finish it understanding where she stands, what could affect future eligibility, and which issues are worth addressing ahead of time.

Phase 2 · Plan

Develop and implement your strategy.

4. **Plan** Barriers & Issues → Priorities & Professional Team → Written Plan
   You finish with: Advance Medicaid Planning Roadmap

5. **Legal** Authority & Documents → Property, Trusts & Transfers → Attorney Review
   You finish with: Legal Planning Review

6. **Financial** Costs & Runway → Asset Treatment & Tools → Strategy & Documentation
   You finish with: Long-Term Care Funding Plan

Phase 3 · Secure

Secure benefits, protect assets, and maintain eligibility.

7. **Apply** Prepare → Submit → Manage
   You finish with: Medicaid Application-Ready File

8. **Protect** What May Be Protected → What May Remain Exposed → What Needs Ongoing Attention
   You finish with: Asset Protection Assessment

9 **Maintain** Ongoing Requirements → Changes & Renewals → Maintenance System
You finish with: Medicaid Monitoring & Maintenance System

What this step produces

A Medicaid Readiness Assessment: a written account of where Mom stands today, what could affect eligibility later, and what is worth watching. Your family's part is the description: what you know, what you're assuming and what you'd ask, with a date on it.

It isn't an eligibility decision. States take Medicaid applications and make those determinations, and nobody here is applying. It's a picture a professional can work from. [1]

What happens next

Your Medicaid planner reviews how Mom's current care and financial picture compares with the Medicaid rules that apply in her state, identifies anything that could affect eligibility later, and notes which areas need review by an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional. The review also records what can be addressed now, what should be monitored, and which changes should prompt another look.

Then comes step four, Plan, which starts from the assessment and turns to priorities and who should be involved. The steps after it bring in the other professionals. The Administration for Community Living describes an elder law attorney as someone who deals daily with the issues surrounding old age, and lists exploring a person's qualifications for Medicaid among the ways one can help. [2]

For a family planning ahead, there's no schedule for the later steps. Knowing the order is enough for now.

Who is involved, by role

- You and your family: gathering, writing down, and noticing what changes.
- Mom: what she knows about her own affairs, and what she wants.
- Your Medicaid planner: reviews how Mom's picture compares with the rules in her state, and notes what needs another professional's review.
- An elder law attorney: the legal questions, including anything about ownership, trusts or transfers.
- A licensed financial professional: the financial questions that come out of the review.
- The state Medicaid agency: decides eligibility if and when someone applies. It has no part in this step.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how things turn out. It doesn't say Mom would qualify for anything or that any amount would be protected, and it isn't legal, financial or tax advice. Families move through the steps at different speeds.

Ready for the next step?

You know where this step sits, what it produces and who is involved after it. The planning interview is the next thing to do from here: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own. That states take applications and make eligibility determinations, and the description of an elder law attorney, come from the Administration for Community Living's long-term care pages.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Applying for Medicaid

2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Will I Need a Lawyer?